

ETHNIC TENSIONS

Ethnic and religious rivalries caused the partition of India. **Territorial disputes** arising from the partition have led to a series of conflicts between neighboring states.

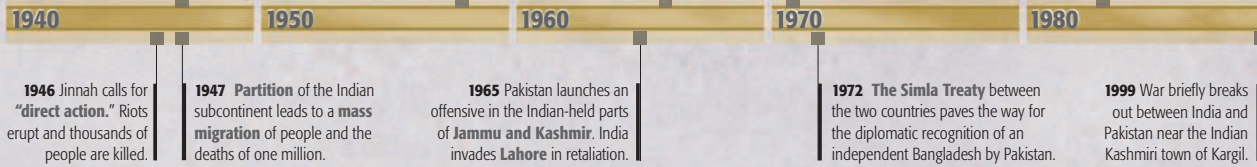
1947–49 India and Pakistan go to war when Pakistan supports a Muslim insurgency in the independent province of **Kashmir**.

1958–60 Disputes arise between Pakistan and India over the rights to water in the Pakistani **Punjab** region.

1966 The **Tashkent agreement** commits the countries to resolve differences through peaceful means and noninterference in each other's foreign affairs.

1971 Civil war breaks out between West and East Pakistan. After the war ends, East Pakistan becomes **Bangladesh**.

1989 Pakistan begins its "moral and diplomatic support" of Muslim militant groups operating in the Kashmir valley. India accuses Pakistan of supporting terrorism.



Muslim nation. Congress president Jawaharlal Nehru, however, would not agree to this plan, nor would his most powerful Congress deputy, Vallabhbhai Patel. Neither felt they could work with Jinnah and were eager to get on with running an independent India.

In July 1947 Britain's Parliament passed the Indian Independence Act, ordering the demarcation of the dominions of India and Pakistan and dividing the assets of the world's largest empire. Under the partition plan, Pakistan had two wings—East and West Pakistan. These were located thousands of miles apart, in the mainly Muslim east and northwest of the region, respectively. India was formed from the remaining area, with the exception of the northern province of Kashmir, which was free to accede to India or Pakistan. On August 14, 1947 Pakistan gained

independence and Jinnah became its first governor-general. At midnight the next day, the independent state of India emerged with Nehru as its first prime minister. As soon as the new borders were announced, more than 12 million Hindus, Muslims, and

Sikhs fled from their homes on one side of the borders to what they believed was refuge on the other side. They traveled on foot, in bullock carts, and on trains. The massive exchange of population left behind a trail of death and destruction. Within two months, about a million people were slaughtered in fierce religious riots. The Sikh population, who were caught on

the Pakistani side of the new border, suffered the highest percentage of casualties. Most Sikhs eventually settled in India's much-reduced border province of Punjab.



Nehru releases a dove

The Indian prime minister, Nehru, launched a dove of peace at his 65th birthday celebrations in 1954. Nehru held office from 1947 to 1964.



Partition riots

Violent gangs roamed the streets of Calcutta during riots that erupted as soon as partition was declared. The sectarian attacks claimed the lives of 4,000 people.

Territorial and ethnic issues continue to cause conflict in the Indian subcontinent.

CONFLICT OVER KASHMIR

India and Pakistan have contested possession of the Muslim-majority state of **Kashmir** since 1947, when the Hindu ruler, Maharajah Hari Singh, gave the province to India. Wars were fought over the territory in 1947–48 and 1965. Since 1989 there has been an independence movement in the Indian-administered part of Kashmir. India blamed pro-Kashmiri militants for the attacks on their parliament in 2001 and on Mumbai hotels in 2008.

SIKH SEPARATISTS

No provision was made for Sikhs when India was partitioned between Muslims and Hindus. From the early 1980s Sikhs began to demand their own state, which they hope to call **Sikh Khalistan**, meaning "Land of the Pure."

NUCLEAR STANDOFF

India and Pakistan conducted nuclear tests in 1998, causing concern in the international community. The UN Security Council criticized the two countries and urged them to stop all nuclear weapons programs. Tensions were reduced in February 1999 after Pakistan and India signed the **Lahore Declaration**, pledging to intensify efforts to resolve all the issues between them. However, the threat of nuclear conflict still remains between the two countries.